

Memphis After Ja: Building Around Jaren Jackson Jr. and the JJJ–Edey Frontcourt

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Executive Summary

Over the past several seasons, it has become increasingly clear that the Ja Morant–Jaren Jackson Jr. pairing that once anchored a 56-win team is no longer sustainable as a long-term core. Morant’s limited availability over the past three years, combined with ongoing fit and timeline concerns, has forced Memphis into a state of prolonged instability, asking Jackson to serve as the constant amid roster turnover and shifting direction.

As the organization weighs a potential pivot, the central question is no longer whether Memphis can replicate its previous iteration, but whether it can construct a more stable, scalable identity around the player most consistently on the floor. That evaluation requires separating Jackson’s elite defensive impact from his structural limitations and understanding how those traits shape roster construction.

This report examines whether Memphis can rationally build around Jaren Jackson Jr. as a long-term defensive anchor, what constraints his profile imposes, and what type of roster construction is required for that approach to succeed. The goal is not to advocate for a teardown, but to assess whether a deliberate reshape is both viable and supported by the data.

1. Why the Grizzlies move on from Ja

1A. Team outcomes with vs without Morant (2025-26 Season)

Table 1: Memphis team profile with vs without Morant (2025-26).

Split	Games	Record	PPG	APG	TS%	ORTG	DRTG	NetRtg
Without Ja	21	11-10	113.0	29.4	56.0%	113.4	113.8	-0.4
With Ja	18	6-12	117.1	28.6	57.0%	112.7	114.9	-2.2

Table 2: On–off court impact of Ja Morant (minutes-based, 2025-26).

Context	Minutes	ORTG	DRTG	NetRtg
Ja ON	510	110.9	117.6	-6.8
Ja OFF	1372	114.9	113.0	1.9

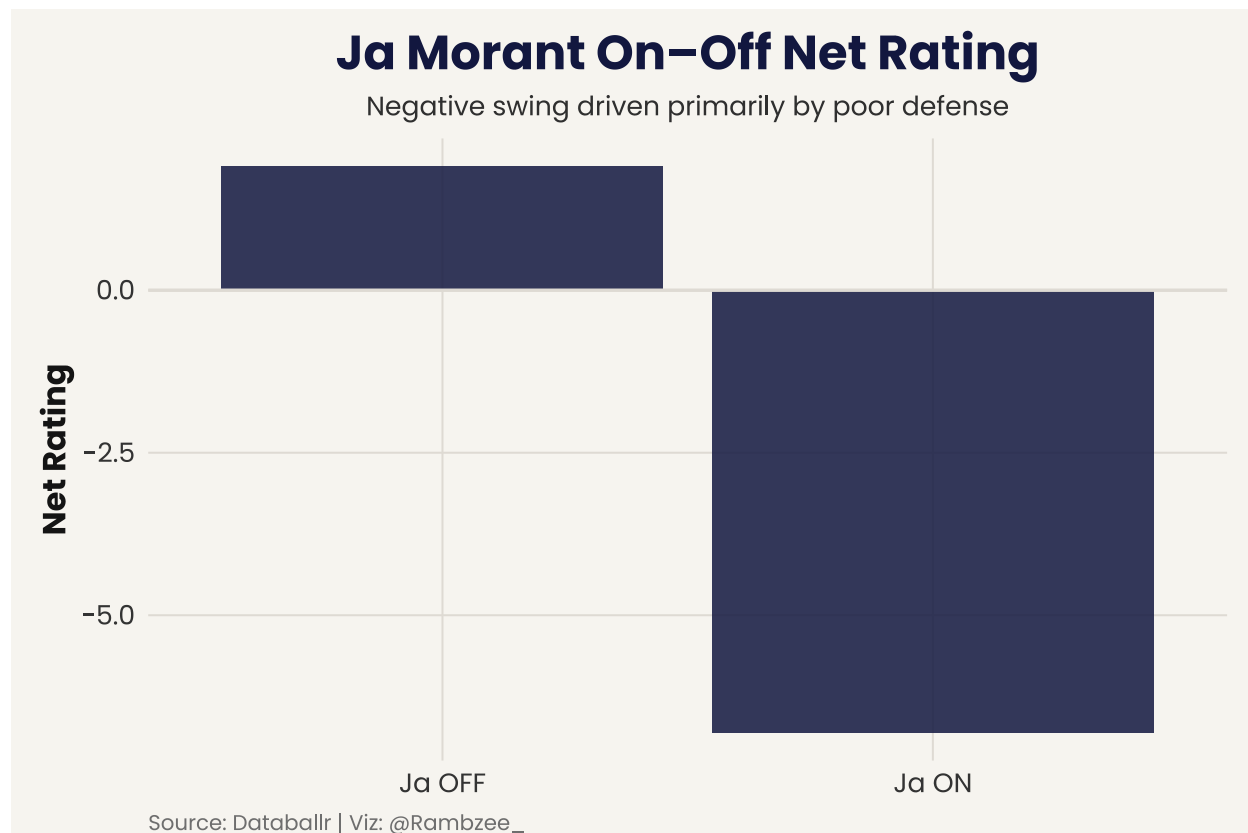


Figure 1: Net rating in minutes with vs without Morant.

In a small sample this season, Memphis has performed better in minutes where Ja Morant is off the floor than on. At the game level, the difference is modest: the Grizzlies post similarly negative net ratings in games he plays versus games he does not (–2.2 with Ja vs –0.4 without; Table 1). The minutes-based on–off evidence is stronger. In 510 minutes with Morant on the floor, Memphis has a –6.8 net rating, compared to +1.9 in 1,372 minutes without him (Table 2), meaning that even within the same games the team has been more effective in non-Morant minutes. This is not a blanket indictment of Morant’s past impact. In limited availability over the prior two seasons, he posted a +7.6 on–off net rating. However, the current season points to a different reality. One with diminished offensive floor raising, defensive slippage, and declining on-court results, which, combined with availability concerns, strengthen the case for a pivot.

1B. Morant profile: efficiency + availability

Table 3: Morant production and efficiency.

Window	Games	PTS	REB	AST	FG%	3P%	FT%	TS%	TOV
This season	18	19.0	3.2	7.6	40.1%	20.8%	90.0%	50.6%	3.6
Last 3 seasons (aggregate)	77	22.4	4.1	7.4	44.5%	28.6%	83.9%	55.2%	3.6

Overall, Morant has been one of the league’s most disappointing players this season. Injuries have limited his availability, and his shooting efficiency has cratered, highlighted by a 20.8% mark from three. While there are still occasional flashes of the explosive creator who once defined Memphis’ rise, the broader trend over the past three seasons is regression. Morant has appeared in just 77 games during that span, and the

on-court impact has declined alongside the availability. At this point, the burden is on Morant to reverse those trends, and it is increasingly unclear whether Memphis views itself as the environment, or the timeline, to facilitate that turnaround. That uncertainty is magnified by the remaining commitment on his contract, which averages roughly \$40 million per year over the next three seasons.

1C. Ecosystem: Young Core

The broader roster context helps explain why Memphis has been able to remain competitive without Morant. Outside of Ja, the Grizzlies' key contributors skew younger, cheaper, and more role-defined. Production is spread across developing players rather than concentrated in a single high-usage guard, allowing the team to maintain spacing, ball movement, and defensive balance.

The most important development has been the emergence of Zach Edey. In a small but meaningful sample, Memphis has posted a +18 net rating in Edey's minutes, compared to -6 when he is off the floor (268 minutes on, 1,420 off). While the sample is limited, the signal is strong. Edey provides elite interior finishing, dominant rebounding, and rim protection, directly addressing the weaknesses that have historically limited Jaren Jackson Jr. With Edey handling possession-ending duties, Jackson is free to operate as a roamer, maximizing his defensive value without forcing him into an unnatural rebounding role.

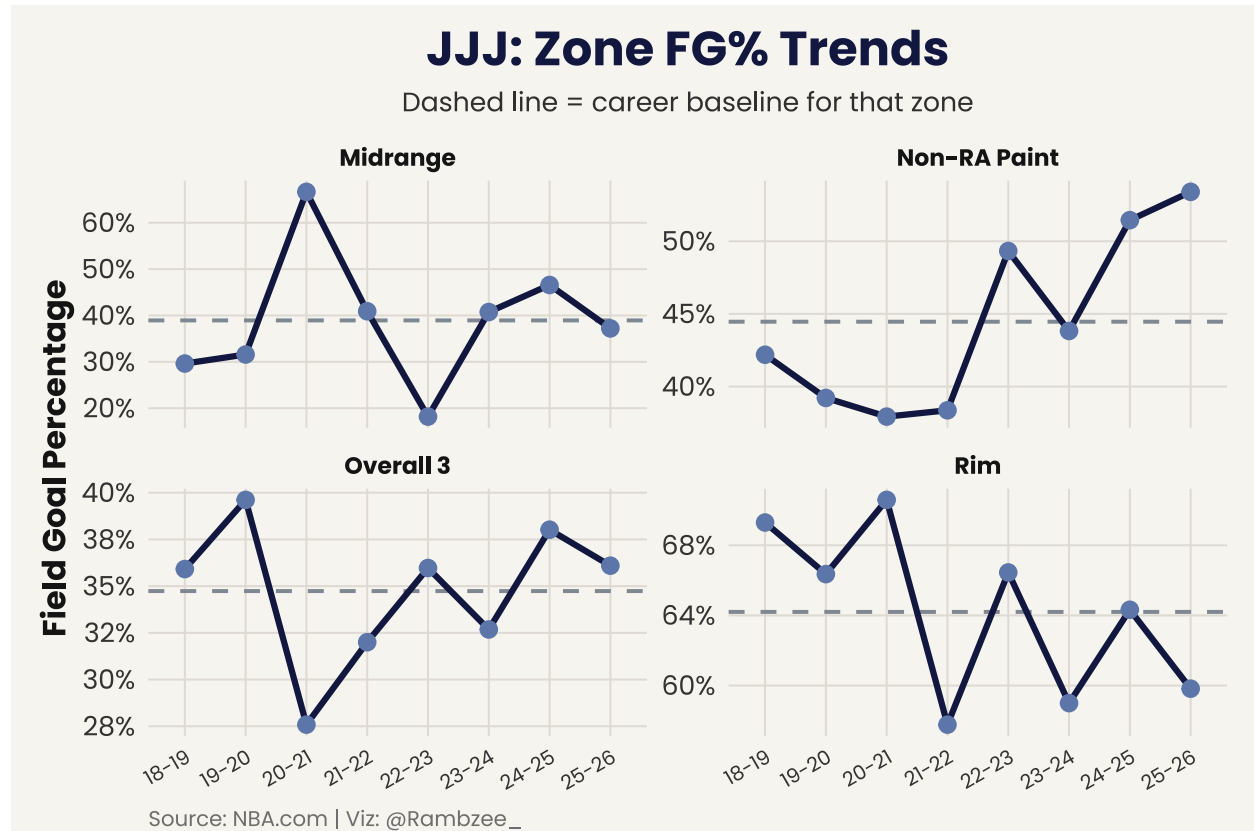
Around that frontcourt, Memphis has quietly assembled a promising young core. Cedric Coward has flashed a legitimate high-end wing skill set with real upside, while Jaylen Wells has quickly established himself as a high-motor, two-way contributor. Combined with recent draft success, the Grizzlies have shown they can be trusted to identify and develop functional rotation players. The remaining challenge is creation, but with short-term stabilizers like Scotty Pippen Jr. and Ty Jerome and a clear development timeline, Memphis increasingly looks positioned to build around Jaren Jackson Jr. rather than forcing a fit around Morant.

2. Jaren Jackson Jr. as the franchise centerpiece

2A. Offensive Upside & Limitations

Table 4: Jaren Jackson Jr. career offensive production.

Season	Age	G	MP	FGA	FG%	3PA	3P%	2P%	eFG%	FTA	FT%	ORB	DRB	TRB	AST	STL	BLK	TOV	PF	PTS
2018-19	19.0	58	26.1	10.2	0.506	2.4	0.359	0.553	0.549	3.4	0.766	1.3	3.4	4.7	1.1	0.9	1.4	1.7	3.8	13.8
2019-20	20.0	57	28.5	13.2	0.469	6.5	0.394	0.540	0.565	3.3	0.747	1.0	3.6	4.6	1.4	0.7	1.6	1.7	4.1	17.4
2020-21	21.0	11	23.5	11.4	0.424	5.5	0.283	0.554	0.492	3.8	0.833	1.5	4.1	5.6	1.1	1.1	1.6	1.4	3.8	14.4
2021-22	22.0	78	27.3	13.3	0.415	5.1	0.319	0.476	0.477	4.4	0.823	1.5	4.3	5.8	1.1	0.9	2.3	1.7	3.5	16.3
2022-23	23.0	63	28.4	13.0	0.506	4.5	0.355	0.585	0.567	4.9	0.788	1.7	5.0	6.8	1.0	1.0	3.0	1.7	3.6	18.6
2023-24	24.0	66	32.2	17.6	0.444	5.5	0.320	0.501	0.494	6.3	0.808	1.3	4.2	5.5	2.3	1.2	1.6	2.4	3.6	22.5
2024-25	25.0	74	29.8	16.4	0.488	5.3	0.375	0.541	0.548	5.4	0.781	1.2	4.4	5.6	2.0	1.2	1.5	2.1	3.5	22.2
2025-26	26.0	37	30.4	14.3	0.479	4.6	0.361	0.535	0.537	4.1	0.763	0.9	4.7	5.6	1.9	0.9	1.5	2.2	3.8	18.5
8 Yrs	8 Yrs	444	28.7	14.0	0.467	4.9	0.351	0.530	0.529	4.6	0.790	1.3	4.2	5.6	1.5	1.0	1.9	1.9	3.7	18.5



Over the past four seasons, Jaren Jackson Jr. has evolved into the most offensively complete version of himself. He has averaged 20.8 points-per-game on solid efficiency while developing legitimate touch around the basket. His jumper is not mechanically pretty, but it is functional, hovering around the mid-30s on roughly five three-point attempts per game over the past two seasons, following an out-of-character dip to 32% in 2023–24. Jackson has become a real mismatch scorer, capable of posting up, attacking closeouts, and finishing in the intermediate areas defenses struggle to fully take away in the modern NBA. That growth was on full-display last season when he was asked to shoulder more scoring responsibility in a more free-flowing system.

Despite that progress, Jackson remains a clear offensive limiter as a passer. He is a legitimately bad play-maker, posting a negative assist-to-turnover ratio in every season of his career (1.5 AST to 1.9 TOV career). His offensive value is real, but narrow. He can score, and he can score efficiently, but he is incapable of creating for others. That constraint places a firm ceiling on any offense with Jackson as its primary hub.

2B. Stocks > rebounds identity

Table 5: Overall rate of games where Stocks > Rebounds (regular season + playoffs).

Games_All	Games_Stocks_GT_REB	Rate
471	55	11.7%

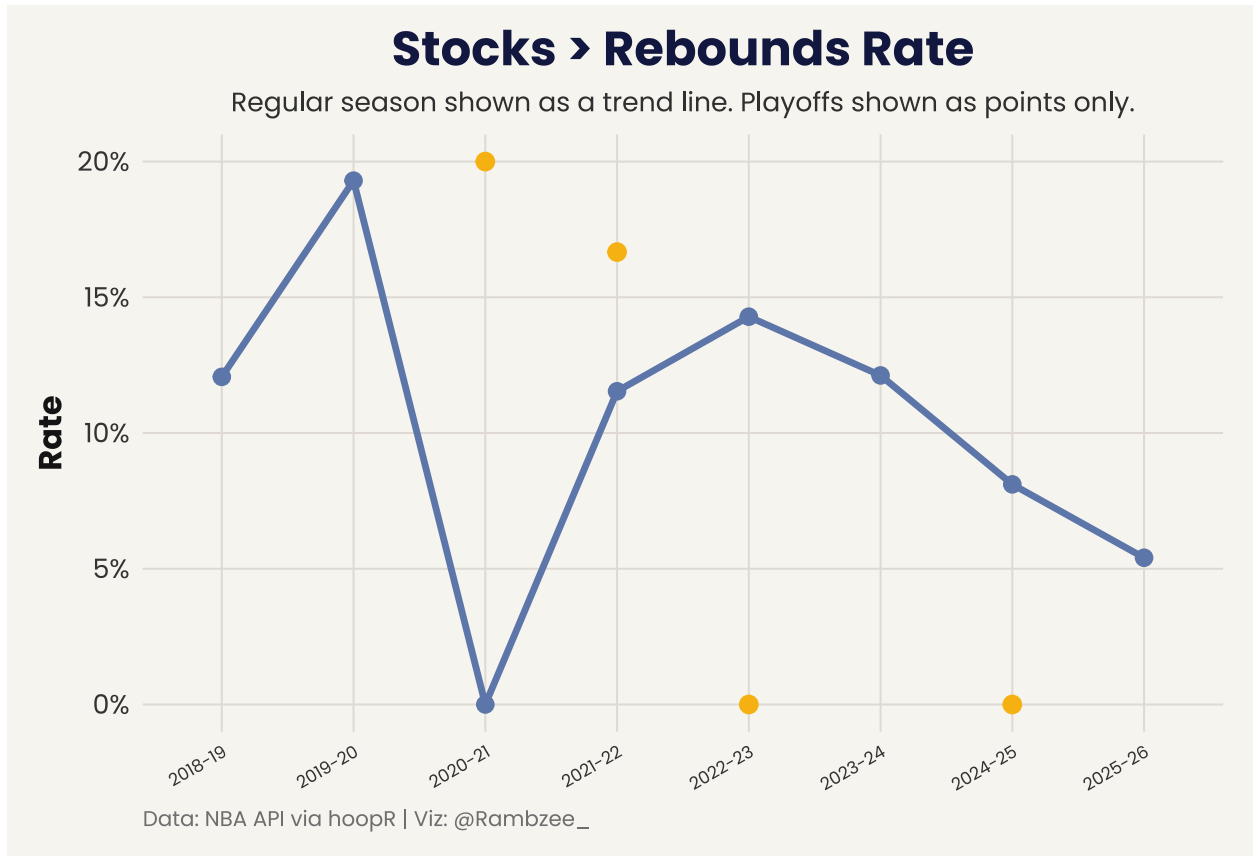


Figure 2: Share of games where Stocks > Rebounds by season and season type.

Jackson's reputation as a stocks machine is well-earned. He has averaged roughly three stocks per game across his career. But that defensive dominance introduces a peculiar and revealing trade-off. In 55 of his 471 career games, including playoffs, Jackson has recorded more stocks than rebounds (roughly once every nine games). That frequency is not just a product of elite event creation. It also reflects a consistent inability to finish possessions on the glass at even a league-average rate.

2C. The rebounding tax

Table 6: JJJ rebounding bucket rates (regular season only).

Games	P(REB < 5)	P(REB >= 5)	P(REB < 7)	P(REB >= 7)	P(REB <= 3)
444	36.5%	63.5%	66.9%	33.1%	23.4%

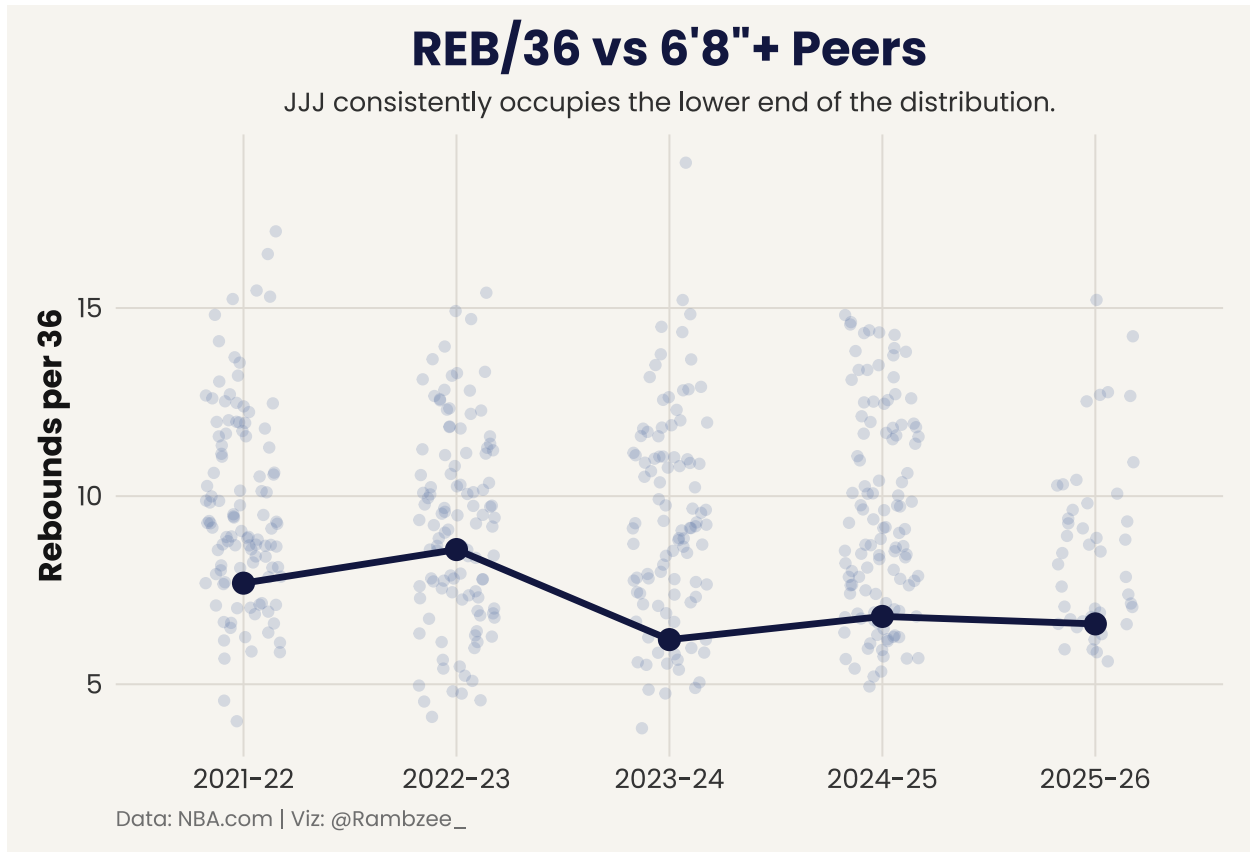


Figure 3: JJJ's REB/36 relative to 6'8"+ peers by season.

Jaren Jackson Jr.'s rebounding profile is defined less by consistent weakness and more by extreme volatility. He has finished with three or fewer rebounds in 23.4% of his career games, a remarkably low floor for a 6'10 big. While there is some ceiling, it appears infrequently. Jackson has recorded seven or more rebounds in roughly 33% of his career games and at least five in 63.5%, still modest benchmarks for his size and role. The problem is not that he cannot rebound, but that bad rebounding nights are far too common.

That volatility shows up clearly in league context. Over the past five seasons, Jackson has ranked in the bottom 20% of rebounders among similarly sized peers in every year but his 2022–23 peak. Across his entire career, he has produced just 32 double-doubles, underscoring how rarely his rebounding meaningfully supplements his scoring. In fact, he has more games with more stocks than rebounds than he does double-doubles, a stark illustration of his unique defensive identity.

3. Zach Edey is the structural fix

Table 7: Lineup indicators tied to JJJ rebounding tax (Last 2 Seasons).

Lineup	Minutes	ORTG	DRTG	Net	OFF TS%	OFF TOV%	OFF ORB%	DEF TS%	DEF TOV%	DEF ORB%
JJJ + Edey	995	119.6	107.6	11.9	59.3%	16.3%	34.1%	54.5%	13.3%	22.1%
JJJ on, Edey off	2015	114.0	114.9	-0.9	57.4%	14.3%	26.4%	57.5%	14.7%	28.0%

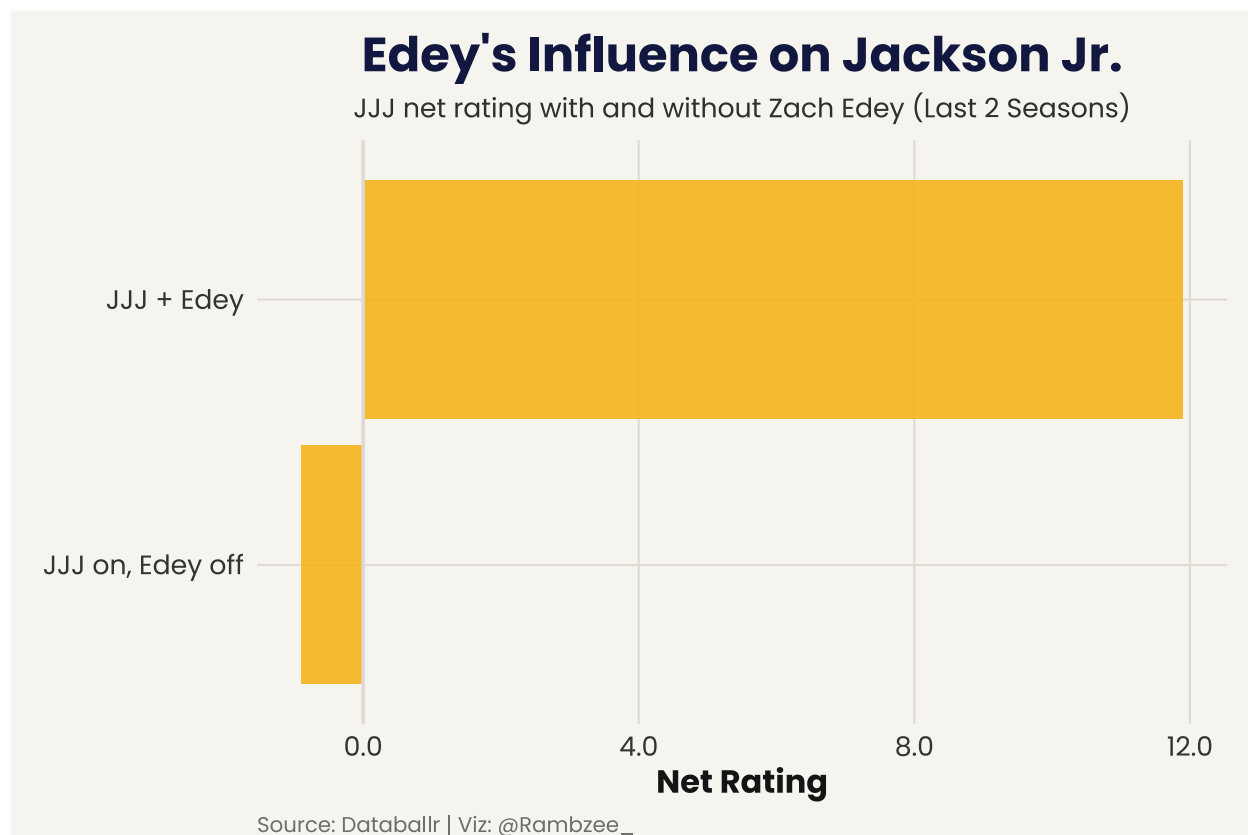


Figure 4: Lineup net rating comparison (manual rows).

When Jackson is paired with Zach Edey, Memphis posts a +11.9 net rating in nearly 1,000 minutes, driven by elite defensive efficiency (107.6 DRTG) and possession control. With Edey on the floor, the Grizzlies rebound 34.1% of their own misses and allow opponents to recover just 22.1%, turning Jackson's defense into clean stops and extending possessions. In contrast, lineups with Jackson and no Edey slip to a -0.9 net rating across 2,015 minutes, despite similar offensive efficiency, as offensive rebounding falls (26.4%) and opponents generate far more second chances (28.0%). That gap in possession-ending reliability underscores the cost of Jackson's rebounding limitations without a dominant rebounder alongside him.

4. Build Rules for a Post-Morant Memphis

- Rebounding at the 5 is non-negotiable.
 - Jackson's defensive value peaks as a roaming help-defender, not a possession finisher. Lineup and on/off data show his stocks only translate into real stops when paired with a rebound-tilting center. Zach Edey's early impact showcases the required archetype: size, box-outs, and defensive rebounding.
- Perimeter = POA defense + shooting gravity.
 - Jackson scales offensively as a second or third option, not as an initiator. Surrounding lineups must defend the point of attack and maintain spacing so he can operate as a mismatch scorer and roamer.
- Creation must be replaced by committee or a new lead option.
 - Jackson is not a playmaking hub. If Morant is moved, Memphis cannot simply shift his shots and touches elsewhere. Shot creation will need to come from other guards and wings who can attack the rim, keep the ball moving, and maintain offensive flow without relying on a single

ball-dominant star.

5. Final Thoughts

The decision to pivot away from Ja Morant is a rational response to availability, regression, and fit. Over the past three seasons, Morant's limited play-time and declining impact have increasingly conflicted with the type of ecosystem Memphis needs to maximize its best remaining star, a tension that this season only reinforces.

Jaren Jackson Jr. is a strong long-term piece to build around. He is an elite defensive anchor, a legitimate mismatch scorer, and one of the few players in the league who can consistently bend offensive game plans through rim protection and event creation. His flaws are very apparent, but they are well-defined. He is not a primary creator or a natural rebounder, and the data makes that clear, but those are problems that can be solved with the right roster around him rather than by forcing him into roles he does not fit.

Zach Edey is the swing piece in that vision. Even in a limited sample, his presence has unlocked the version of Jackson that Memphis actually needs, one where defensive disruption reliably turns into ended possessions. Whether Edey becomes the long-term answer or simply the prototype matters less than the lesson he provides. Jackson works best next to a true rebound anchor. If Memphis commits to that principle, develops its young perimeter core, and remains flexible about adding a true creator down the line, this becomes a quick pivot firmly supported by the data.